

VER. 26.1

Authenticity

Armors and Weapons
Aesthetics and Decorations

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1. Implementation

The document has been created and approved by the General Assembly of 09.11.2024.
The document and its rules have been implemented since the 2025 season.

2. Definition

Armors and weapons aesthetics are very important for the fighters' appearance and sports representation.

The development of our sport will be easier with well-maintained and properly finished armor and weapons.

Crafting armor and its parts is a process mostly made by hand with the help of different hand tools such as hammers and files, even during the surfacing process and polishing. Thus, it is not rare to find such traces on artifacts, even in the corners of a highly polished armor.

3. General Requirements

The following aesthetics are allowed:

- Matte polish *(see Section 4 below),*
- Satin Polish *(see Section 5 below),*
- Mirror Polish *(see Section 6 below),*
- Blackening and Bluing *(see Section 7 below).*

All types of aesthetics must:

- be based on historical sources,
- be homogenous regarding the whole set of armor: it is not allowed to mix different aesthetics in the same armor set unless specifically written in the specific requirements,
- have a steel surface that does not present strong forging remains, big filing traces, and modern grinding marks,
- be properly polished, any highly unpolished armor part is **Denied**,
- be free of rust.

Decoration

An armor can be decorated with different methods, such as:

- etching,
- engraving,
- plating and gilding.

Helmets can be decorated with the medieval spirit, with crest, torse, burlets or orle for example.

Example of burlet:



Picture from Age of Craft ©

Painted armor

As the topic of painted armors is very controversial among armor experts, historical sources can't stand a clear position about painted armor.
We have historical sources for the late 15th century helmets (mainly Sallets) but nothing relevant for the 14th century nor for armor parts.
Therefore, any painted armor metal part, metal buckler or weapon is **Denied**.

4. Matte Polish

4.1. Definition and Sources

A basic polishing method, widely used during the Middle Ages. Its appearance is flat and gray, and subtle marks from the polishing process are still visible. A utilitarian finish that hides scratches and holds a protective oil film well.
The basic and most common finish is the matte polish. It is recommended for all types of 14th and 15th century armor and weapons.

It is **Approved** for **14th century**, **Transitional** and **15th century armors.**



Armet, on display at the Metropolitan Museum of Arts (MET) - 1440 - New York (USA)

4.2. Specific Requirements

The whole armor or weapon must be matte polished.

It is **Denied** to have an armor set mixing matte polish with other aesthetics.

Matte polish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding or plating.

4.3. Examples of Approved Finishes

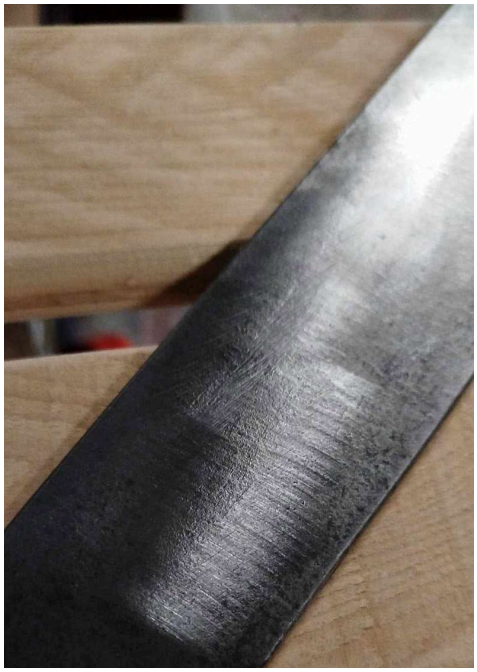


Picture from Medieval Extreme ©



Picture from Master Uley ©

Acceptable grinder marks



4.4. Examples of Denied Finishes

Excessive rust



Unpolished weapons







Pictures from The Medieval Things ©

5. Satin Polish

5.1. Definition and Sources

Satin polish has a semi-reflective surface with a subdued sheen, the polishing marks are small and only visible upon close inspection. A practical polishing method that balances functionality with a refined appearance. Armors are polished with multiple grinding grits to obtain an intermediary reflective finish. It is not as shiny as mirror polishing.

It is **Approved** for **14th century**, **Transitional** and **15th century armors.**



Montefeltro Altarpiece by Piero della Francesca - 1472 - Italy
Note: the helmet in this art is mirror polished

5.2. Specific Requirements

The whole armor must be satin polished or a mix of satin and mirror polished.

It is **Denied** to have an armor set mixing matte polishing parts with satin polishing parts.

It is **Denied** to have an armor set mixing black/blued polishing parts with satin polishing parts.

Satin polish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding or plating.

5.3. Examples of Approved Finishes





Pictures from Master Uley ©



Picture from Black Dog Armoury ©

6. Mirror Polish

6.1. Definition and Sources

A late-period polishing technique that gained popularity in the 15th century. Metal plates are polished with progressively finer grit until polishing marks are not visible, resulting in a reflective sheen. This finish requires high maintenance to keep it looking its best. Armors are polished with multiple grinding grits reaching into the 1000 grid to obtain a beautiful reflective finish.

It is **Approved** for **14th century**, **Transitional** and **15th century armors.**



Armor of Sigismund von Tirol, Kunsthistorisches Museum Wien - 1484 - Austria

6.2. Specific Requirements

The whole armor must be satin polished or a mix of satin and mirror polished.

It is **Denied** to have an armor set mixing black/blued polishing parts with mirror polishing parts.

Mirror polish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding or plating.

6.3. Examples of Approved Finishes





Pictures from Master Uley ©



Pictures from J. Amiot ©

7. Blackening and Bluing

7.1. Definition and Sources

This finishing method appeared in the mid-15th century sources, the metal plates are carefully heated to high temperatures to obtain a black or blue finish by treating the steel with oils

We lack historical sources for the 14th century to allow those finishes for armors of this period.

Blackening and blueing are **Approved** for **15th century armors.**

Blackening and blueing are **Denied** for **14th century** and **Transitional armors.**

***Note**: We want to gather data on blackened armor. Which different technique and material armorers can use and which is the result in terms of aesthetics, maintenance, prevention of corrosion, sustainability etc. If you want to submit your work, please send us an email to: authenticity@buhurtinternational.com*

Acceptable methods of blackening/bluing are as followed:

- **Temperature bluing**

  The metal plates are carefully heated to adequate temperatures to obtain a blue oxide finish on the surface of the steel.

- **Oil blackening**

  This technique involves applying oils, such as linseed oil, to steel, which is then baked in an oven or applied to heated steel at relatively low temperatures. The process results in a deep black, protective finish. However, it requires regular touch-ups to maintain its appearance and protective qualities.

- **Chemical blackening/bluing**

  Modern chemicals normally intended for use on firearms are permitted for armor. Hot-blue treatment is preferred, as it results in a deeper and more durable finish, but be mindful of how this could affect heat-treated steel. Cold-blue can be repeatedly applied to darken the surface of the steel and also to touch up hot-blued steel.



Greenwich Armour replica (1595) Plates formed by Robert MacPherson & Jeff Wasson, decoration and finishing by Chris Gilman



Georgsaltar' (Meister der Georgslegende) Köln, Wallraf-Richartz-Museum - 1460-1465 - Germany



Armet, German - 1550 - Metropolitan Museum of Arts



Foot combat armor, Royal Armouries - 1591 - England

7.2. Specific Requirements

The whole armor must be of the same method of blackening/bluing.

It is **Denied** to have an armor set mixing black/blued polishing parts with other aesthetics.

Blackening/bluing finish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding, or plating.

It is **Denied** to use paint to reproduce a black/blued finish.

7.3. Examples of Approved Finishes





Pictures from Master Uley ©

7.4. Examples of Denied Finishes

Unpolished helmet, trying to imitate proper blackening



Picture from The Medieval Things ©

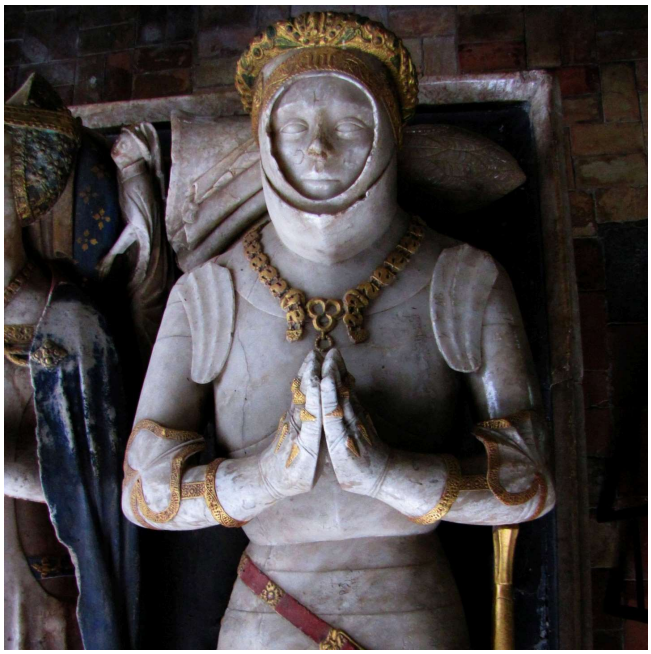
8. Decorations

8.1. Definition and Sources

Armors were often decorated with different methods to display the owner's status. The following decoration methods are documented by historical sources: etching, engraving, plating and gilding.

Helmets were decorated with fabric or metal elements such as crest, burlet, torse and orle.

It is **Approved** for **14th century**, **Transitional** and **15th century armors**.



Sir William Phelip, Lord Bardolph - 1441 - England





Late 14th century, MET Museum



BL Royal 20 C VII Chroniques de France ou de St Denis - 1380/1400 - France

8.2. Specific Requirements

All decorations must be based on historical sources. It is permissible to combine different decorative elements as long as they form a cohesive and visually consistent design across the entire armor set. No offensive symbols, words, or political messages of any kind may be used. If a logo is included, it must be stylized to align with medieval aesthetics and designs.

8.3. Allowed Decoration Techniques

8.3.1. Etching

It is allowed to etch symbols, inscriptions, and motifs inspired by medieval artwork. The etching may be carried out by traditional or modern techniques, but the resulting designs should be in keeping with the aesthetics of the period. Exact historical reproductions are not required; however, modern logos, offensive imagery, and contemporary text or symbolism must be avoided.

8.3.2. Engraving

It is allowed to engrave symbols, lettering, and decorative motifs consistent with medieval sources. Engravings may be done by hand or with mechanical tools, so long as the overall appearance remains historically inspired. As with etching, the use of modern, offensive, or overtly contemporary themes is prohibited.

8.3.3. Plating

It is **Allowed** to decorate the edges of an armor part with metal plates. The following materials can be used:

- Copper,
- Brass,
- Gold,
- Silver,
- any other metal that can be documented by historical sources.

8.3.4. Gilding

It is **Allowed** to use gilding as a decoration on armor and weapons. The following materials can be used:

- Copper,
- Brass,
- Gold,
- Silver,
- any other metal that can be documented by historical sources.

8.3.5. Helmet decorations

It is **Allowed** to decorate a helmet in the medieval spirit. It must be based on historical sources. Any textile or leather part must conform with the "*Textiles and Leather*" document.

8.3.6. Shield Decorations

It is **Allowed** to decorate shields with paint and other embellishments in the spirit of medieval artwork. While exact historical reproductions are not required, the overall design must closely approximate medieval styles and avoid any modern logos, symbols, or contemporary imagery.

8.4. Examples of Approved Decorations







Pictures from The Medieval Things ©





Pictures from R. Desgranges ©

8.5. Examples of Denied Decorations

Painted helmets





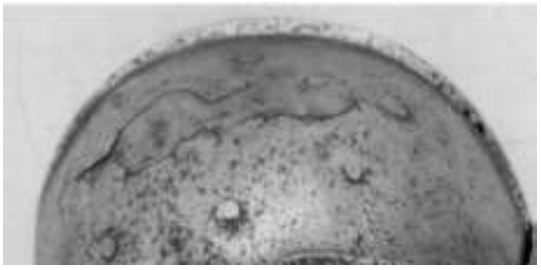
Pictures from The Medieval Things ©

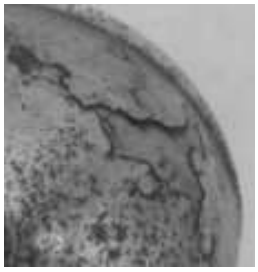
9. Repairs

9.1. Definition and Sources

Armors were sometimes repaired to increase its durability. In the Middle Ages, the most common way to repair an armor was to rivet a metal plate from beneath. From a buhurt point of view, it will be important to respect period techniques for visible repairs.

It is **Approved** for **14th century**, **Transitional,** and **15th century armors**.





9.2. Specific Requirements

Visible repairs must be executed with period techniques, for example with a riveted patch installed on the inside of the armor part and riveted.

Repairs must be clean and not dangerous for other equipment elements.

Any modern reparation is allowed if properly concealed. Any type of welding must be grinded/filed and polished on the outside.

10. Changelog

Below, we will keep track of all the changes made over the lifetime of this document. This way, all our members can see how the documents are changing over time.

January - 2026 (V. 26.1)
Formatting redone for consistency and readability. Except points listed below, no content changes.
Add: “1. Implementation” (and subsequent modification of all Title numbers in the document)
Clarification:

- Split of “2. Definition” and “3. General Requirements” and subsequent title-numbers modifications)

February-2025 (V2025.02)
- rephrased 6.2
- formatting: grammar and formatting improvements

11-Nov-2024
-Add Document has been created